

To Find a Gate

“To Find a Gate” is a brief AD&D Forgotten Realms adventure for 4 - 6 PCs of any level, class or alignment. The adventure is designed to allow a DM to introduce into his campaign gates and planer travel. This adventure can be very brief if the characters state their desire quickly to the bugbears leading to an adventure with more role playing than combat. If the adventure occurs as it is written, there should be no combat at all. This adventure assumes that the characters will peacefully approach the ruins and seek to speak with the beholder Zythalarlr.

This adventure does not follow the normal outline of most adventures, in that there are few descriptions of rooms and the adventure has no set course of action beside getting the characters to the gate. Blindfolded for the whole trip through the complex, the characters are escorted by the bugbears in a manner that will confuse and disorientate them. The DM must be very descriptive of the smells and sounds of the complex, since the characters are going to be unable to see. The bugbears that inhabit this complex, that were bred through selective breeding practices, trained and raised by Zythalarlr are unusually intelligent. All of the bugbears are experienced warriors and veterans of battles with other adventuring bands seeking to take control of the gates. The bugbears are proficient in the common tongue and speak some of the other common languages found in the Realms, thanks to Zythalarlr’s teaching. The weapons of the bugbears are of excellent to good quality, thanks again to the beholder, who realizes that guards armed with poor equipment are ineffective.

Before running this adventure, the DM should prepare and keep in mind several things.

First, prepare a riddle either of your own or from a published source for the players to answer. After selecting the riddle, plan for all the possible answers you can, and determine which would be close enough to be considered correct and which although close are still wrong. Keep in mind the adventure can become a party slayer if the DM chooses a super hard poem, or one with an obscure answer. Consider the players and attempt to use a riddle that will challenge their intellect but not stump them. A sample riddle is provided with this adventure, but should the players’ characters desire repeat trips, more riddles are needed.

Second, decide the route and methods the bugbears are going to take to confuse the characters before leading them to Zythalarlr. The adventure lacks room descriptions because the characters are blindfolded, but be descriptive with smells and other clues. The bugbears may take several days, leading the characters in a large loop or a figure eight, stopping often to camp to further confuse the characters. The bugbears are going to march around the characters and make all sorts of noise to further the confusion among the adventurers.

Third there is no exact location of the gate, you can place it in any room, or upon another level of the complex. A few of the rooms are left undescribed for you to fill in if necessary.

The ruins of Gate are mentioned on page 45 of The North; Guide to the Savage Frontier, boxed set and page 41 of FR5, The Savage Frontier. The supplement I, Tyrant would be useful for a better understanding of beholders and their kin, but is not required. The Dragon magazine article “Theory and Use of Gates” which is found in the Best of Dragon Magazine #2 on pages 52-54 contains suggestions for campaign use of gates. Some suggestions for gates, their use and destinations may be found in the Planescape setting and the Manual of the Planes hardbound book.

For the DM

The PCs have previously learned about the ruins of Gate, the beholder, and the bugbears. They have previously obtained a map with the location of the ruins. The DM can drop this module into any region that suits his campaign. The PCs have learned that in order to access the gates, they will have to answer a riddle from the beholder Zytharlir or be killed and eaten by the bugbears and beholder. The PCs have ascertained which color of gate they seek from other sources such as a sage. The module starts as the PCs are approaching the entrance to the ruins.

The bugbears purposely lead the characters on a confusing route through the stronghold, avoiding any areas with young or females. The bugbears chose a route with the fewest possible places the adventurers could escape and areas that are strongly fortified incase the adventurers suddenly attack. Demihumans such as dwarves will still be able to use their racial abilities, but are still going to be confused by the methods used by the bugbears.

For the Players

Read or paraphrase the following to the players:

You have finally gained the edge of the ravine that holds the Ruins of Gate. Inside the yawning black hole decorated with bugbear clan talismans are the gates that you seek. Finally, your goal is in sight but the thought of openly walking into a bugbear stronghold makes your palms sweat. On top of that, there is the ancient beholder Zytharlir to deal with. The worries of what riddle he will ask are constantly playing on your mind. Surely, the beast has had centuries to think of devilish riddles that no man can answer.

As the characters approach the ruins, they are carefully watched by a small band of eight goblins mounted on worgs. They will send two members back to the stronghold entering by a secret way to warn the bugbears of the adventurer’s approach. This warning will allow the bugbears to ready their defenses and at the same time, the clan sub-lieutenant will dispatch 10 bugbears to greet the adventurers. They will depart the ruins in four rounds after receiving the orders. When the group of bugbears departs, the goblins will exit by the secret tunnel again and return to shadowing the characters. Should a battle ensue with the characters, the goblins will attack from behind.

Goblins (8): INT 5; AL LE; AC 6; MV 6; HD 1-1; hp 5, 4 (x5), 3, 2; THACO 20; #AT 3; Dmg 1-6; MR

Nil; SZ S; ML 10.

Worgs (8): INT 5; AL NE; AC 6; MV 18; HD 3+3; hp 21 (x2), 18, 16 (x2), 15, 14 (x2); THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; MR Nil; SZ M; ML 11.

Descent into the Basin

Descending into the basin is not arduous but the low grass and shrubs will not offer any concealing cover. While the characters are pondering their fate, they see a small squad of ten bugbears climb from the ruins and head towards their location. Should the characters seek to avoid the advance group, the goblins on worgs will keep the bugbears informed of the adventurer's position. From this, the adventurers should determine that they are under observation. By using magic to hide their presence, the adventurers will alarm the goblins who will conclude the adventurers are attacking. These goblins will warn the squad and the stronghold. A similar warning will sound if the adventurers attack the goblins. A large force of bugbears will come storming from the ruins. The bugbears do not really care about the goblin "scouts" and will not mourn their loss, but it will take some smooth, fast-talking from the adventurers to smooth things over and prevent the bugbears from slaying them.

Should the adventurers climb down the basin walls and head straight for the squad of bugbears, they will be openly shadowed at a respectful distance by the mounted goblins. When the two groups meet, the bugbear squad leader Thragol will attempt to determine the reason of the adventurers' intrusion into their territory. The squad leader speaks passable common and can understand the adventurer's request. Should the characters state that they wish to see the beholder, all the bugbears will break into evil grins and escort the characters into the ruins. The squad leader will state plainly that the adventurers will remain with the escorting squad, and that any hostile action will result in the immediate slaughter of the adventurers. He also explains that once inside the complex, they will be blindfolded and roped together, before being led to the beholder.

The bugbears are not overtly hostile but they make it clear that they expect the characters to fail to answer the riddle correctly. The rest of the bugbears do not share their names and will pointedly ignore any request for names of any clan members or other information about the clan. They make comments about the gear of the characters and may remark and joke about how tasty certain characters are going to be especially any demihumans.

Bugbears (9): INT 6; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 21; 18; 16 (x3); 15; 13 (x2); 12; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; morning star; shield.

Thragol, Bugbear Squad Leader: INT 9; AL CE; AC 4; MV 9; HD 4+1; hp 29; THACO 16; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +3 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; mace; shield.

Entering the Ruins.

The ruins above ground lack any useable structures and have been reduced to piles of stone. A dark

stinking hole littered with numerous bones and speckled with dried blood hints at what might lie below. Several clan talismans encircle the entrance. Most are made of demihuman bones with several dried scalps of different creatures adorning the shafts of the wooden poles. A single circular flight of stone stairs descends into the depths of the earth.

The adventurers arrive in room #1A and as long as Thragol escorts them, no harm will befall them. All of the passages and rooms the adventurers travel through are dimly lit with foul smelling torches. Unless specified, all ceilings are 15' high within the ruins. The blindfolded characters will only be able to determine that the halls are dimly lit and may be able to make out the placement of torches.

Rooms #1A, #1, and #2, a Trap.

The flight of stairs stop in a narrow, bone-littered room, 5' wide and 15' long. The room has three doors. There is a door in the center of the northern and southern walls and another door on the western wall. All are shut, locked, and show frequent use. A thick layer of dried mud, grass, and twigs covers the walls.

The bugbears have laid a cunning trap. Murder holes perforate the northern and southern walls. The murder holes are plugged with mud, but when the trap is sprung, the bugbears push the plaster out and fire their crossbows into the room, creating a crossfire. There are eight bugbears each in rooms #1 and #2 with 10 loaded heavy crossbows. They will fire as fast as they can with the bugbears without a crossbow loading for the ones shooting. They have a store of 75 quarrels stacked in the corner.

When the adventurers enter, Thragol approaches the southern door and speaks quietly through the door. He answers some questions too softly for the characters to hear but soon the door opens and four bugbears armed with morning stars enter the room. Each carries a shield, and has a guisarme leaning on the wall in the previous room. The adventurers are then tightly blindfolded and roped together.

Bugbears (20): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 23; 21; 19 (x7); 18 (x5); 17 (x4); 15 (x2); THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; heavy cross bows; shields; morning stars.

Room #3.

Bugbears (18): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 24; 22 (x5); 20 (x6); 17 (x4); 15; 13; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; guisarmes.

Room #4.

Bugbears (17): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 23; 22; 19 (x6); 17 (x4); 16 (x4); 14; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; morning stars; shields.

Bugbear Sub-Lieutenant: INT 9; AL CE; AC 3; MV 9; HD 4+1; hp 31; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +3 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; morning star; shield.

Room #5.

Bugbears (30): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 23; 22; 21; 19; 18 (x2); 17 (x3); 16 (x4); 15 (x7); 14 (x3); 13 (x2); 12; 11 (x2); THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; spears (x10); shields; swords.

Room #6.

Bugbears (10): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 19; 18 (x4); 17; 16 (x2); 15; 13; THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; morning stars; shields.

Room #7.

Bugbears (30): INT 7; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 3+1; hp 23; 22; 21; 19; 18 (x2); 17 (x3); 16 (x4); 15 (x7); 14 (x3); 13 (x2); 12; 11 (x2); THACO 17; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +2 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; spears (x5); battle axes (x5); shields; morning stars.

Room #11, 13, 14, & 15.

Before running this final encounter, decide which room the beholder is going to use. He uses a different one each time, and always prepares a counter attack. Each of the chosen rooms has a pit that leads to the lower levels and makes a convenient escape route. The bugbear escorts stop at the entrance of this room to remove the blindfolds and untie them. The adventurers are then told to enter the room.

This large room is (insert size) and is occupied by a round, 6'-diameter; horribly monstrous creature with a large, drooling maw lined with teeth the size of daggers. Several of its eyestalks are constantly twitching searching the room. You notice that three of its eyestalks lie on its body as though they are dead. The body of the monster is badly scarred, and the rotting remains of meals are evident, jammed between those dagger-like teeth.

This is an *illusion* cast by the beholder. The beholder, the bugbear shaman, chief, and four squad leaders are beside the beholder but hidden by an *illusionary wall* spell. The real beholder floats over the escape pit. The assembled monsters will attack only if the party fails to answer the riddle correctly within the allotted time or if they attack the illusionary beholder.

While behind the *illusionary wall* the beholder will use *ventriloquism* to make the illusion speak. With a booming voice like two granite flagstones crashing together, it speaks to the PCs:

“Why have you bothered Zythalarlr, the Keeper of the Gates? Are you foolish enough to seek death so readily, you who have such short lives anyway?”

After stating their reasons, the beholder will consider a moment and then speaks again:

“I will ask one riddle that you will answer correctly within four hours or Zythalarlr and the bugbears will feast upon your delectable carcass. Answer correctly and you will be given access to the gates. My riddle is thus:

What walks on four legs in the morning

Two legs in the afternoon

And three legs in the evening?”

The PCs will have exactly four hours to answer this riddle correctly. The answer is man, mankind, or a human.

After the riddle is given, the adventurers are locked into a large iron cage until they shout for release with the answer or their time expires. At the end of every hour a sweet, childish voice calls out the remaining time.

A correct answer causes the adventurers to be blindfolded again, and led on another confusing trip through the complex until the bugbears are instructed to free them at the entrance to the gates. However, this is not done until the beholder, the bugbear shaman, chief, and four squad leaders have occupied the room.

An incorrect answer or if the time expires without a correct answer, an immediate attack occurs from the assembled bugbears. The beholder with the leading bugbears will not enter the battle unless necessary or victory seems uncertain for the bugbears. Zythalarlr will not use his eyes unless the battle goes poorly for the bugbears, preferring to save their powers for later if needed. He will avoid melee unless attacked directly. The squad leaders each carry a signal whistle that they will blow immediately upon attack. Within one round, the bugbears from the adjoining rooms join the battle, and within four rounds, the entire fighting force (240 male fighters) has descended upon the room.

The Entrance

Suddenly you are gruffly told to stop and your blindfolds are ruffley removed. You find yourselves facing a narrow black stone block with a single open door. The block is 20’ square and has a single archway six-feet high in the center. Faint light shines from inside.

The adventurers are instructed to enter the block of stone.

The Gates

This large room is much larger than the outside dimensions of the block. Obviously, magic is used to contain so large a room within the smaller block. This room is 50' square and along the three walls not occupied by the entry are 20 blocks of stone of various colors.

These are the gates, their color and destinations are as follows:

Gate Color	Destination
Blue	Water
Black	Negative Energy
Grey	Smoke
Brown	Earth
Red	Fire
Light Blue	Ice
Grey with White Speckles	Ooze
Crystal	Positive Energy
Steel Grey	Mechanus
Yellow	Arcadia
Green	Mount Celestia
Orange	Elysium
Green with White	Olympus
Dark Red	Bytopia
Dark Red with Yellow	The Abyss
White	Sigil
Menagerie	Pandemonium
Purple	The Outlands
Grey	The Beastlands
Pink	Arborea

The adventure should end here. However, if battle occurs, here are the statistics for the assembled monsters:

Bugbears Leaders (4): INT 9; AL CE; AC 4; MV 9; HD 4+1; hp 29; 28; 27; 25; THACO 16; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +3 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; morning stars; shields.

Bugbear Shaman: INT 10; AL CE; AC 5; MV 9; HD 4+1; hp 21; THACO 16; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; mace; Spells: *ceremony, detect magic, light, prayer*.

Bugbear Chief: INT 10; AL CE; AC 4; MV 9; HD 4+1; hp 32; THACO 16; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Surprise, +4 to damage; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 13; long sword +1.

Zythalarlr (beholder): INT 16; AL LE; AC 0/2/7; MV FL 3 (B); hp 69; THACO 7; #AT 1; Dmg 2-8; SA Magic; SD Anti-magic ray; MR Nil; SZ L; ML 18. Central eye power: anti-magic ray with a 140-yard range in a 90 degree arc; Smaller eye powers: #1 dead; #2 charm monster (as spell); #3 dead; #4 telekinesis (250 pound weight); #5 flesh to stone (as spell, 30-yard range); #6 dead; #7 fear (as wand); #8 slow (as spell, but only a single target); #9 cause serious wounds (50-yard range); #10 death ray (as a death spell, with a single target, 40-yard range).

Concluding the Adventure

The Ruins of Gate can be used repeatedly by the PCs to access the gates, braving the beholder's riddles each time. The players may eventually (as they grow more powerful) begin to consider attempting to cleanse and

possess the ruins. The DM should flesh out the rest of the ruins and modify the numbers of monsters populating it, to fit the needs of his campaign. The clan of bugbears under the beholder is unusually large. They are raised to revere the beholder and with such a strong figurehead leading the clan, the bugbears are less inclined to internal strife. The beholder plans defense and frequently travels the ruins to inspect the defenses. The beholder knows that some day, the ruins will come under attack and he has been preparing for that day for several centuries. There are several more levels below the one that the adventurers first encounter, who knows what other horrors are waiting below. If the DM has access to the accessory I, Tyrant, there are many suggestions within for stocking a beholder lair and some nasty tricks to use against invading forces. Also, perhaps Zytharlir is only the agent of some greater evil lower within the complex, where perhaps there is access to the Underdark.